Technologies suitable for XUL-based products

Let's now take a look at some of the compatible technologies that have been created to complement the development of XUL-based products.

XBL

The eXtensible Bindings Language (XBL) is a markup language that defines special new elements, or "bindings" for XUL widgets. With XBL, developers can define new content for XUL widgets, add additional event handlers to a XUL widget, and add new interface properties and methods. Essentially, XBL empowers developers with the ability to extend XUL by customising existing tags and creating new tags of their own.

By using XBL, developers can easily build custom user interface widgets such as progress meters, fancy pop-up menus, and even toolbars and search forms. These custom components can then be used in XUL applications by specifying the custom tag and associated attributes.

Overlays

Overlays are XUL files used to describe extra content for the UI. They're a general mechanism for adding UI for additional components, overriding small pieces of a XUL file without having to resupply the whole UI, and re-using particular pieces of the UI.

Overlays are a powerful mechanism for customising and extending existing applications because they work in two related but highly different ways. In one respect, overlays are synonymous with "include" files in other languages because an application may specify that an overlay be included in its definition. But overlays can also be specified externally, enabling the designer to superimpose them upon an application without changing the original source.

In practical terms, this enables developers to maintain one code stream for a given application, then apply custom branding or include special features for customers with a completely independent code base. This leads to an overall solution that's easier and less costly to maintain in the long run.

There's an additional benefit of overlays for software developers who intend to add features to Mozilla that they wish to keep proprietary. The Netscape Public License (NPL) and Mozilla Public License (MPL) require developers who alter original work (source code files that are provided with Mozilla) to release the source code for these changes to their customers.